nurses, using foul language, making vulgar gestures, spitting at them and even roaming around naked. They had to be later shifted to a temporary isolation ward at a private educational institute.[16] In Hyderabad too, at Gandhi Hospital, family members of a jamaat attendee who had tested positive for the virus and were quarantined, attacked doctors who were on call and damaged hospital property.[17] In Madhubani (Bihar), bullets were fired and stones were pelted at policemen on duty who had gone to a community to trace the jamaat returnees. The local police had received intelligence that a crowd of a hundred-odd people had gathered at a mosque. When they reached the mosque, the locals not only attacked them but chased them for a kilometre, eventually leading to the police car being overturned into a pond.[18] Several doctors were also being discriminated against by being disallowed to continue living in their societies.[19] Many such incidents came to be reported concerning the authorities. Several state governments responded swiftly by booking and detaining the attackers under the National Security Act. Others brought in special laws to offer protection to doctors and other medical personnel.[20] However, the existing state laws did not have the wide sweep and the ambit required to ensure complete protection, especially since they did not cover harassment at home or workplace and were focused on physical violence. In addition, the penal provisions contained in these laws were not stringent enough to deter mischief.

The prime minister, in his daily media reports, had been receiving stories of violence against the police, doctors and health workers from all around the country. Not only was it worrying that the frontline workers who were trying to save lives by putting their own at risk were being attacked, but it was also of grave concern to him that the acts of violence were most often communal in nature—pitting Muslims against Hindus and vice versa. Such a situation would also hamper the medical community from performing their duties to their optimum best, killing their morale. The safety of our doctors and healthcare workers was a critical need in the hour of national health crisis. Our healthcare workers were our frontline soldiers in the battle against COVID-19. They deserved our highest respect and encouragement at this moment rather than being harassed or being subjected to violence. We would have to have a zero-tolerance policy against such disgraceful acts, he concurred. Growing increasingly